Imperator Black — Quick Reference rules v0.5

The round

• **Initiative:** each side 2d6 + the Nerve of its Leader with the highest Nerve. Winner chooses who activates first. Reroll ties.
• **Activations:** alternate one model at a time; two actions each. When one side runs out, the other finishes.
• **End of round:** (1) Bleeding/Critical clocks; (2) Down models test 8+ to recover; (3) unhit models in cover lose 1 Suppression; (4) hazards; (5) mission clock and alert (p. 3); (6) clear Activated (Overwatch stays).

Attributes

Attr.	Used for
MOV	Inches per Move action (usually 5-7). Training, exoskeletons and heavy kit all show here.
SHT	Hit rolls, Suppressive Fire and reaction shots.
FGT	Close combat exchanges.
PHY	Throwing, forcing doors with a breaching tool, holding on in decompression, getting up when Down.
NRV	Breaking tests, Find Cover, and initiative for Leaders.
TEC	Medic actions, hacking, putting out fires and other technical work.
W	Wounded markers a model can carry; one more puts it Down.
SZ	Physical bulk: 1 small drone, 2 human, 3 large (walkers and vehicles are larger). Used by rules for hatches, cover and vehicles.

A test is 2d6 + the named attribute, −1 per Suppression, −1 if Wounded; 8+ unless stated. Rank is a label only.

Actions

Action	Effect
Move	Up to Move. Obstacle +2". Contact with an enemy starts close combat.
Shoot	Hit roll vs a visible target.
Aim	+1 to the next Shoot this activation.
Suppressive Fire	Auto only. Hit: +1 Suppression (+2 if beating 8 by 3+). No damage.
Throw	Grenade; 2d6 + Physique, 8+ to land on the point. Handy.
Overwatch	Last action. Up to two reactions before this model next activates.
Find Cover	In the open within 1" of micro-terrain: 2d6 + Nerve, 7+ Light, 10+ Heavy.
Rally	Remove 1 Suppression from self or a friend within 6" (2 with a Leader).
Medic	Treat a Down/Bleeding/Critical friend in contact.
Interact	Objective, door, console or charge within 1".

Reactions

• **Who:** a model not yet activated (it becomes Activated), or a model on Overwatch (up to two).
• **Triggers (in its line of sight):** enemy Moves (interrupt anywhere along the move); Shoots, Throws, Suppressive Fire or Interacts (after); comes into view of an Overwatch model for any reason (at once).
• **Door opens:** (1) resolve the opening; (2) cracked-in grenade lands; (3) far side reacts; (4) opening side's Overwatch reacts; (5) opener carries on. Once per model per door.
• **One action:** Shoot the trigger at −1; Move up to half to cover or out of sight; or Find Cover.
• **Timing:** never simultaneous. The trigger resolves in full first (damage, Suppression, casualty shock); then only models still able may react. Down: no reaction; Pinned: Find Cover only.
• No reactions to reactions. Pinned: Find Cover only. 2+ Suppression removes Overwatch. Cumbersome can't react.

Shooting

• Throw 2d6 hit dice **with** the damage dice. Hit: 2d6 + **Shoot** + modifiers ≥ **8**. Natural 2 misses; double 6 is a critical (+1 row).
• Damage total → wound row, +1 if critical, then step down by Armour − AP. Row ≤ 0: no effect.
• Range: beyond short −1, beyond double −2 (shotgun −2/−3). No maximum range.
• Cover: Light ≥⅓ hidden or a model in the way; Heavy ≥½ hidden behind solid material.

Hit modifier	Value
Aim	+1
Target in Light cover	-1
Target in Heavy cover	-2
Each Suppression on shooter	-1
Shooter has any Wounded markers	-1
Moved earlier this activation (not Handy)	-1
Reaction or Overwatch shot	-1
Unbraced in zero-g (not Void-trained)	-1
Target in darkness beyond 6" (no low-light gear)	-2

Wound table

Row	Total	Result
1	2–3	Shaken: +1 Suppression
2	4–4	Rattled: +2 Suppression
3	5–5	Grazed: +1 Suppression
4	6–7	Wounded: add a Wounded marker. More markers than Wounds: Down
5	8–9	Wounded and +1 Suppression. More markers than Wounds: Down
6	10–11	Down: may recover (end-of-round test 8+, or Medic)
7	12–13	Down and bleeding: dies at end of third round unless Medic 8+
8	14–15	Critical: dies at end of next round unless Medic 10+
9	16–18	Dead
10	19+	Dead; friends within 1" gain 1 Suppression

Rows above 10 count as 10. Wounded = −1 to all rolls.

Weapon and armour keywords

Keyword	Effect
Handy	Ignores the moved-this-activation penalty.
Auto	Auto N: may use Suppressive Fire. Shoot or Suppressive Fire may engage up to N models within 3" of the first target, one roll each, -1 after the first.
Suppressing	A hit also adds 1 Suppression.
One per round	May fire once per round, including reactions.
Cumbersome	An extra -1 when firing after a Move; cannot fire as a reaction.
Explosion	Explosion (X): affects every model within X" of the point of impact that has line of sight to it. One damage roll for all (chapter 6).
Confined	+1 wound row to models in an enclosed compartment of 6" x 6" or smaller.
Breach	Can destroy doors, hatches and thin bulkheads.
Silenced	Shots do not count as noise for the alert track.
Sealed	Protected from vacuum and smoke; resists decompression tests (+2).
Heavy	Bulky armour. Its weight is already reflected in the wearer's Move.
Suppressive Fire (action)	Auto weapons only. Hit roll, no damage: +1 Suppression, or +2 if the roll beats 8 by 3+.

Imperator Black — Quick Reference (2)

Weapons

Weapon	Dmg	Short	AP	Keywords
Sidearm	2d6	8"	0	Handy
SMG	2d8	12"	0	Handy, Auto 2
Carbine	2d8	18"	0	Handy
Shotgun	2d12	10"	0	Handy
Rifle	2d8	30"	0	—
Heavy rifle	2d8	30"	1	—
LMG	2d8	30"	0	Auto 3, Suppressing
Compact LMG	2d8	18"	0	Handy, Auto 3, Suppressing
DMR	2d10	48"	0	—
AT launcher	2d12	36"	1	One per round, Cumbersome
or high explosive	d8+d 10	36"	0	Explosion (2)
Auto rifle	2d8	24"	0	Auto 2
HMG	2d10	30"	1	Auto 3, Suppressing, Cumbersome
Anti-materiel rifle	2d12	48"	2	Cumbersome

Melee	Dmg	AP
Unarmed / weapon butt	2d4	0
Knife or bayonet	2d8	0
Breaching tool or heavy blade	2d10	0
Boarding axe or combat blade	2d10	1

Armour	Value	Keywords
None	0	—
Flak	1	—
Void suit	1	Sealed
Composite plate	2	—
Void plate	2	Sealed
Heavy plate	3	Sealed, Heavy

Close combat

• Starts when a model Moves into contact (a Move: it can trigger reactions). Resolves at once, in exchanges.
• Each exchange: both roll 2d6 + **Fight**. Charge +1 (first exchange); +1 per friend also touching the enemy (max +2); −1 per Suppression; −1 if Wounded.
• Higher wins and rolls its melee damage on the wound table. Tie: both +1 Suppression. No effect: loser still +1 Suppression.
• A model at 5 Suppression that loses is overpowered: Down, or captured if allowed.
• After each exchange, loser then winner declares Continue or Break; it ends only when both break (move 1" apart).

Tokens (cube colours)

Token	Cube	Use
Activated	Blue	Activated or reacted unactivated this round. Clear at end of round.
Overwatch	Green	Two when placed; remove one per reaction.
Suppression	Yellow	One per point, max 5.
Wounded	Red	One per Wounded marker.
Bleeding / Critical	Black	On a Down model (lay it on its side): 3 / 1 rounds left; remove one each later round end. On a door: locked.
Hack progress	Red / White	On the door: red per failed attempt (+1 each, max 3), white per success.
Last-known position	White	The enemy marker. Also marks a surrendered model.

Alerted enemy element: turn its unit cards sideways.

Grenades and breaching

• Throw up to double range: test 2d6 + **Physique** (−1 beyond range), 8+ lands on target. Miss: lands short by the miss (min 1"). Natural 2: lands 2" in front of the thrower. Zero-g: bounces past instead.
• Frag: one damage roll for all; step down per model's Armour; Heavy cover −1 row; same compartment ≤ 6"×6": +1 row.
• Breaching charge: place (Interact), detonate later (action). Door destroyed; within 1": 2d6; far side within 2": +2 Suppression, no reactions this round.
• **Crack and throw:** within 1" of a closed, unlocked door: open it and Throw in one Interact, before anyone reacts. Miss: lands in the doorway.
• Locked door: charge; breaching tool (Interact, test 8+); or hack (Interact, 2d6 + Tech, quiet): Basic 7+; Secured 9+; Hardened 9+ ×2; Military 10+ ×2. +1 per earlier failed attempt on it (max +3).

Grenade	Range	Radius	Effect
Frag grenade	8"	2"	2d8 damage
Flashbang	8"	3"	+2 Suppression; removes Overwatch; cannot react until end of round
Smoke grenade	8"	2"	Blocks line of sight through the area until end of next round

Suppression, morale, casualties

• Suppression: −1 to all rolls each (max 5). **Pinned at 3+**: only Rally, Find Cover, Move to cover/out of sight, Shoot from cover.
• Casualty shock: friend within 6" goes Down or Dead: +1 Suppression (+2 if the Leader).
• Breaking: half a fireteam out → each tests 2d6 + **Nerve** (+1 Leader within 6") at **every** activation; fail = both actions moving away (normal Moves). Enemy elements count as fireteams; Automated never test. Off the board via entry point = fled.
• Wounded markers from rows 4–5; any marker −1 to all rolls; more markers than Wounds → Down. Wounded is a flat −1, not per marker. Down: end of round 2d6 + **Physique** 8+ to rise, no Wounded penalty (gets up with 3 Suppression, markers set to Wounds); no test while a standing enemy is in base contact. Capture (if allowed): Interact in contact with a Down enemy. Medic action, 2d6 + **Tech**: Down 8+ (auto with Medic), Bleeding 8+ (becomes Down), Critical 10+ (stabilised).

Ship hazards

• **Zero-g:** push off in a straight line; end on a surface or keep drifting. Unbraced −1 to shoot, throw and fight (not Void-trained).
• **Decompression:** each model tests 2d6 + Physique, 8+ (+2 Sealed), or is dragged d6" to the breach; doors seal at end of round; vacuum follows.
• **Vacuum:** unsealed models ending an activation there go Critical. Shooting is silent. No fire or smoke.
• **Fire:** 2d6 damage on entering or ending there (Sealed +1 armour); spreads on 10+, out on 2–3; extinguish 2d6 + Tech, 8+.
• **Darkness:** seen only within 12"; −2 beyond 6" unless Low-light; a model that shot this round is seen at −1.

Imperator Black — Quick Reference (3): Missions

Alert track (0–6)

Raises the alert	By
Loud noise (chapter 10)	+1
Very loud noise	+2
An element raises the alarm	+1
Each check-in the clock reaches or passes (a check-in is missed)	+1

At	Threshold (once each, at the end of the round)
2	Contacts move: at the end of each round, every contact moves 6" toward the marker (or toward the player entry if there is no marker), by the shortest route. Unrevealed elements become Alerted when revealed.
4	Reinforcements: at the end of the round, the tier's reinforcement element arrives at the enemy's entry, Alerted.
6	Lockdown: the mission type's lockdown happens at the end of the round.

Mission clock

Size	Player force	Die	Limit
Small mission	Up to 8 player models	d4	20 min
Large mission	9 or more player models	d6	30 min

• The mission sets its size, or the size of the player force does. The size gives the clock die and the time limit.
• The clock starts at 0. At the end of each round, roll the clock die: that many minutes pass. Then resolve the alert track's effects, including any check-in just passed.
• Check-ins fall every 5 minutes from minute 10 (10, 15, 20 and so on). Each check-in the clock reaches or passes raises the alert track by 1.
• When the clock reaches the time limit, time has run out: the mission ends.

End of each round: (1) roll the clock die and move the clock; a check-in reached or passed: alert +1. (2) Alert threshold effects. (3) Time run out: the mission ends.

Complications (d6)

d6	Complication
1–2	**None:** No complication.
3	**Early warning:** The alert track starts at 1.
4	**Reinforced:** One more contact than the tier lists.
5	**Tight window:** The time limit is 5 minutes shorter.
6	**Hazard:** Aboard ship, the vessel's first hazard (chapter 11). On land, Night (chapter 12).

Extraction and the end

• A player model that leaves by its airlock or its own edge is extracted, with whatever it carries (data, cargo, a hostage or prisoner in base contact).
• The mission ends when every player model is extracted, Down, Dead or captured, or when time runs out.
• Models still on the board are left behind; left behind Down: captured (campaign).

Contacts

• A contact is revealed when a player model can see it, or ends a Move within 3" of it. Roll on the tier's contact table.
• Place the element with its first model on the chip and the rest within 2", in cover where they can be; then remove the chip.
• A revealed element is Unaware while the alert track is below 2, Alerted from 2 on. Either way, newly placed models cannot react until the current activation ends.
• A contact that moves into sight of a player model is revealed at once.

• **False alarm:** Nothing there: crew who fled, a ventilation fan, a stray animal. Remove the chip.
• **Booby trap:** A tripwire charge: resolve a frag grenade centred on the chip (2d8, radius 2"). It is Very loud. Remove the chip.

Objectives: taking them

Seize data or cargo. A model in base contact may Interact to take it: automatic for a model with a hacking rig (data) or Physique 2 or more (cargo); 2d6 + Tech (data) or Physique (cargo), 8+, for anyone else. Data travels with the model that copied it; cargo is carried, and the carrier has −2" Move. If the carrier goes Down, a model in base contact may take it with an Interact.
Lockdown (6): The enemy locks it down: taking the objective now needs two successful Interacts, and a Hack of Secured (9+) first if it is data.

Recover personnel. The hostage (unit card: Hostage) starts bound in the objective. A player model in base contact frees them with an Interact. From then on the hostage is a player model: it activates after the model that freed it, every round, and must end each activation within 3" of a player model if it can.
Lockdown (6): The enemy moves the hostage: at the end of the round, the nearest enemy model within 6" of a bound hostage moves it up to 6" toward the enemy's exit, with it.

Sabotage. A model in base contact sets a charge with an Interact (models without breaching charges use the target's own systems: same Interact). The target is destroyed at the end of that round (Very loud), unless an enemy model is in base contact with it then, which disarms the charge.
Lockdown (6): The enemy guards the targets: place one new contact within 3" of each target still standing.

Capture a high-value target. The high-value target (HVT) is the tier's HVT model, placed at the objective with the guard. Take it by overpowering it in close combat, capturing it while Down (chapter 7), or when it surrenders: the HVT tests to surrender (chapter 10) whenever it is Pinned or Wounded with a player model within 6" and no friend within 6". A prisoner moves with a player model in base contact, which halves that model's Move.
Lockdown (6): The HVT runs: from now on it activates first each enemy turn, using the Handler profile's escape line toward the enemy's exit. If it leaves the board, it has escaped.

Grades

Each mission type grades **Decisive** (objective done and no player model Dead), **Marginal** (objective done) or **Failure**; the mission sheet gives the exact wording.

Imperator Black — Quick Reference (4): After-action campaign draft

After-action, in order

(1) Casualties and injuries; (2) prisoners; (3) the grade's rewards and the node's outcome; (4) XP and the citation; (5) advances.

1. Casualties

• Dead: the soldier's name goes on the force's roll of honour.
• Down at any point in the mission, and alive at the end: roll on the injury table.
• Left behind Down: captured. A holding site node joins the map, linked to the node where it happened, at the same threat tier, revealed. Strike it to bring the soldier home.
• Left behind standing: the soldier makes their own way back and is out for 1 turn.
• Wounded markers alone leave no lasting injury.

2d6	Injury
2	**Dies of wounds:** The soldier dies. Roll of honour.
3	**Crippled:** Permanently −1 to an attribute: roll a die, 1 Move (−1"), 2 Shoot, 3 Fight, 4 Physique, 5 Nerve, 6 Tech (0 at least). Out 3 turns.
4–5	**Severe wound:** Out 2 turns.
6–8	**Wounded:** Out 1 turn.
9–10	**Patched up:** Fit for the next mission.
11–12	**Close call:** Fit for the next mission, and +1 XP.

Modifiers: -1 the soldier was Bleeding or Critical during the mission; +1 a Medic action saved or treated the soldier during the mission (chapter 7); +1 medical bay level 2 or 3. 2 or less reads as 2; 12 or more as 12. Out: campaign turns missed, ticking down at Upkeep.

2–3. Prisoners and rewards

Result	Reward
Decisive	+3 Requisition, +1 Standing. The node is taken.
Marginal	+1 Requisition. The node is taken.
Failure	−1 Standing. The node stands, its threat tier 1 higher (4 at most).
HVT extracted as a prisoner	+2 Intel and +1 Evidence.
Each other prisoner extracted	+1 Intel (2 at most per mission).
Data seized (seize mission)	+1 Intel; +1 Evidence as well at threat tier 3 or 4.
Two or more soldiers Dead	−1 Standing.

A taken node also gives its own reward (node table).

4. XP (each soldier who deployed)

XP	For
+1	Deployed on the mission
+1	Did the objective's action: took it, freed the hostage, set a charge that destroyed a target, or took the HVT
+1	Put one or more enemy models Down or worse, or made one surrender
+1	The mission was graded Decisive
+1	The citation: one soldier per mission, your pick, for the deed of the mission (record it)

5. Advances (every 5 XP)

d6	Advance
1	+1 Shoot (4 at most; 4 is legendary)
2	+1 Fight (4 at most)
3	+1 Physique (3 at most)
4	+1 Nerve (4 at most)
5	+1 Tech (3 at most), or +1" Move (once per soldier)
6	A skill: Leader, Medic, Marksman (next level), Scout or Low-light; or choose any row above

• Each time a soldier reaches 5, 10, 15 (and so on) XP, roll a die on the advance table. If the result is already at its cap, choose another row.
• Rank follows advances: a Regular becomes a Veteran at 3 advances and an Elite at 6 (a Green soldier becomes Regular at 1). Rank is a label (chapter 1).

Citations and honours

• **Medal:** A soldier with three citations is decorated: +1 Standing (once per soldier), and the name goes on the honour roll.
• **Unit honour:** A team earns a mark when all its fit soldiers deploy and the mission is Decisive. At 3 marks it takes one honour from the list below, for good.

Breachers: +1 to the team's tests to set charges and open or force doors. · **Ghosts:** The first Loud noise the team makes in a mission does not raise the alert track. · **Steady:** +1 to the team's breaking tests. · **Hunters:** +1 to hit Unaware models.

Then: Upkeep and Events

Upkeep: recovering soldiers tick down one turn; ship upgrades finish; move the turn marker. Events: roll 2d6 (campaign sheets).

Imperator Black — Quick Reference (5): Two players draft

Forces

Size	TV	Board	Clock
Patrol	350	A 36" × 36" land table, or a deck (chapter 11)	20 min, d4
Strike force	600	A 48" × 48" land table	30 min, d6

• Agree the game size. Each side builds a force of whole teams from its faction's tables of organisation (chapter 9), with a total Troop Value no higher than the size's limit (chapter 15).
• A team may leave slots empty, but must field at least half of them, and its Leader if it has one.
• Choose loadouts from each troop's options. Use the troop's listed TV whatever its loadout; players who want exact values can work out the chosen loadout with chapter 15.

Missions (d6)

d6	Mission	Hidden information
1	Meeting engagement	Both sides deploy in blinds.
2	Hold the ground	No blinds: both forces deploy openly.
3	Salvage race	Both sides deploy in blinds.
4	Raid: seize data or cargo	The defender's garrison deploys in blinds.
5	Raid: sabotage	The defender's garrison deploys in blinds.
6	Raid: recover or capture	The defender's garrison deploys in blinds, and the mission's secret (below) is written down before deployment.

Meeting engagement: Casualty points only.
Hold the ground: From round 2, at the end of each round, each objective a side controls scores it 1 point. A side controls an objective with a standing model within 2" of it and no standing enemy model within 2".
Salvage race: A model in base contact takes a cache with an Interact (as cargo, chapter 13: the carrier has −2" Move; a model in base contact takes it from a carrier that goes Down). A cache carried off a side's own edge (or out by its own entry on a deck) scores that side 3 points.

Ending and winning

• The game ends when the mission clock reaches its time limit (the size sets the die and limit), when one side has no standing models on the board, or at the end of a round in which one side withdraws.
• **Withdrawal:** at the end of a round, a side with more than half of its starting models Down, Dead, captured or fled (not counting a reserve still off the board) withdraws; the game ends. In an even fight, the withdrawing side scores no mission points that round.
• Each enemy model Down, Dead, captured or fled at the end of the game: 1 point. A Leader: 2. A model with Wounds 2 or more: 2 (a Leader with Wounds 2 or more: 3).
• Add each side's mission points and casualty points. The side with more wins: **Decisive** if it has at least twice the other side's total and at least 3 more; otherwise **Marginal**. Equal totals: a draw (both Marginal).

Blinds

• A **blind** is a numbered chip standing for one team, or up to four models of a team (note which on paper). A **decoy** is a blind standing for nothing. Each side in a blinds mission adds two decoys; a raid defender adds three.
• A blind activates as one activation: it Moves up to 6" (difficult ground and obstacles as normal) and may do nothing else. It cannot be shot, blocks nothing, and doesn't react.
• A blind is **revealed** when an enemy model can see it, when it ends a Move within 3" of an enemy model, or at the start of any of its side's activations, if its player chooses. A blind that would cross an enemy model's line of sight during a Move stops and is revealed there.
• On reveal, place its models with the first on the chip and the rest within 2" of it, in cover where possible, then remove the chip. A decoy is simply removed. Models revealed during the enemy's activation cannot react until that activation ends.
• A blind revealed at the start of its own side's activation: place its models, then activate one of them as that activation.

Raids

• The defender splits its force: a **guard**, at most a quarter of its force's TV, placed openly within 3" of the objective (of the first, for sabotage); a **reserve**, at least a quarter, off the board; and the **garrison**, the rest, in blinds.
• The defender places the garrison's blinds and its decoys anywhere more than 12" from the attacker's entry (aboard ship, not in the docking passage or a tile touching it). Then the attacker deploys as chapter 13 says.

The alarm

• Until the alarm is raised, the garrison and guard are **unready**: an unready model may not Shoot, Throw, take Overwatch or react, and may Move only half its Move. Blinds do not move.
• The alarm is raised at the end of an activation in which a defender model sees an attacker model, is hit, or hears Loud noise (12" aboard ship, 24" on land) or any Very loud noise (chapter 10). From then on, no defender model is unready.

The alert track

• At **2**: the garrison's blinds may move, up to 6" each activation.
• At **4**: the reserve arrives at the defender's entry at the end of the round (it may deploy in blinds).
• At **6**: the mission type's lockdown happens at the end of the round, carried out by the defender: the defender moves the hostage, runs the high-value target for its exit, or places a new blind within 3" of each standing sabotage target (a reserve team still off the board, or a decoy if none is left).

The attacker is graded with the mission type's table (chapter 13). The defender's grade is the mirror: attacker Decisive is defender Failure, Marginal is Marginal, and attacker Failure is defender Decisive.